

Research Statement

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September 2026

Research Overview

My research examines how accounting reduces information frictions in the real economy and shapes corporate decisions and resource allocation. Specifically, I study how accounting systems affect the availability, timeliness, and reliability of information about firms' production costs, profits, and product risks. Several of my studies combine economic theory with novel empirical strategies to develop and test frameworks linking accounting information, product-market distortions, financial frictions, and aggregate fluctuations.

To connect firm-level information frictions to aggregate outcomes, my first research strand develops and tests the underlying microeconomic mechanisms. This work addresses two limitations at the intersection of accounting and macroeconomics. On the accounting side, research on macroeconomic issues often lacks a clear theoretical foundation: research designs are not closely tied to central macroeconomic questions, and the mechanisms underlying empirical findings remain insufficiently explained.¹ On the macroeconomics side, general equilibrium models have yet to fully incorporate how imperfections in accounting systems generate capital-market frictions. My studies examine how these frictions affect firms' financing and investment decisions, providing microeconomic foundations for understanding their aggregate consequences.

Building on this focus on information frictions, my second research strand examines how firms interpret and respond to accounting information and events. It studies how disclosure, reporting standards, and fraud shape firms' beliefs and decisions through both rational and behavioral channels, including the formation of macroeconomic expectations. These papers examine inflation-risk disclosure, the role of accounting standards in antidumping investigations, and how punishment and changes in public trust affect corporate behavior and contracting.

Extending the analysis to other frictions in the real economy, my third research strand examines how product- and labor-market frictions shape corporate innovation. These studies focus on how constraints on competition and access to skilled labor affect firms' incentives and capacity to innovate.

Recognition and Impact

Since 2020, I have published seven papers in the *Journal of Accounting and Economics*, the *Journal of Accounting Research*, the *Journal of Monetary Economics* ($\times 2$), *Management Science*, *AEA Papers and Proceedings* (formerly known as *American Economic Review Papers and Proceedings*),

¹In the *Journal of Accounting Research*, Ray Ball argues that the literature underestimates accounting's "fundamental contribution" to aggregate welfare (Ball, 2024).

and *The Antitrust Bulletin*. My current revise-and-resubmit papers are “Nominal Rigidities, Earnings Manipulation, and Securities Regulation” at *Management Science*, “Trust and Contracts: Empirical Evidence” at the *Journal of the European Economic Association*, and “Nationalistic Labor Policies Deter Financial Innovation” at *The Review of Financial Studies*.

My research has received international recognition through conference invitations and a best paper award. “Accounting Standards and Antidumping Investigations” (Sun, Wei, and Xie, 2025) was invited for presentation at the 2024 *Journal of Accounting and Economics Conference* at Stanford Graduate School of Business. “Undisclosed Material Inflation Risk” (Konchitchki and Xie, 2023) was invited to the 2022 *Journal of Monetary Economics special issue conference, “Inflation: Drivers and Dynamics”*, jointly organized by the Federal Reserve Bank of Cleveland and the European Central Bank. “Fake Entry” (Schmalz and Xie, 2024) was invited to the 2023 *Adam Smith Workshop* at the University of Oxford. “Punish One, Teach a Hundred” (D’Acunto, Weber, and Xie, 2026) received the 2018 *China Financial Research Conference Best Paper Award* (2018 中国金融学年会最佳论文奖)

Beyond these selected recognitions, I have presented my research at major international conferences and research meetings, including the Financial Accounting and Reporting Section Midyear Meeting (FARS) ($\times 4$), meetings of the National Bureau of Economic Research (NBER) ($\times 4$), the American Economic Association Annual Meeting (AEA), the American Finance Association Annual Meeting (AFA) ($\times 6$), meetings of the Asian Bureau of Finance and Economic Research (ABFER) ($\times 3$), the Barcelona GSE Summer Forum, the China Financial Research Conference ($\times 2$), the China International Conference in Finance (CICF) ($\times 6$), the China International Conference in Macroeconomics (CICM) ($\times 2$), the European Finance Association Annual Meeting (EFA) ($\times 4$), meetings of the Centre for Economic Policy Research (CEPR), and the Society for Financial Studies Cavalcade (SFS) ($\times 3$).

I have also been invited to speak at leading universities, including the University of California, Berkeley; Peking University; Fudan University; Shanghai Jiao Tong University; the Hong Kong University of Science and Technology; the University of Hong Kong; the Chinese University of Hong Kong; Tilburg University; the University of Melbourne; and Singapore Management University. Other invitations include talks at the Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation and the Federal Reserve Bank of Cleveland, as well as presentations at focused conferences, workshops, and symposia: the London Business School Accounting Symposium, the University of Texas at Dallas Fall Finance Conference, the Adam Smith Workshop, the European Winter Finance Summit, the Indian School of Business Summer Research Conference in Finance, the Luiss Finance Workshop, and the Mitsui Symposium on Comparative Corporate Governance and Globalization.

In terms of academic citations, articles citing my work have appeared in leading accounting journals, including the *Journal of Accounting Research*, the *Journal of Accounting and Economics*, *The Accounting Review*, *Review of Accounting Studies*, and *Contemporary Accounting Research*. Citing articles have also appeared in the *Journal of Political Economy*, *The Review of Economic Studies*, the *Journal of Finance*, the *Journal of Financial Economics*, *The Review of Financial Studies*, *Management Science*, the *Review of Finance*, the *Journal of Financial and Quantitative Analysis*, the *Journal of the European Economic Association*, *American Economic Journal: Microeconomics*, and the *Annual Review of Financial Economics*. Beyond academia, my work has been covered by Bloomberg, the Chicago Booth Review, ProMarket, Yahoo Finance, and Securi-

ties Times.

The following sections explain how these studies connect accounting information to financing, disclosure, trade, and contracting, before turning to related work on competition and innovation.

1. Accounting and the Macroeconomy: Product-Price Rigidity and Financial Frictions

Several papers in this section grew out of my dissertation at HKUST, while later studies extend its inquiry into how output-price stickiness, inflation, and firms' capital-market frictions interact.² The seminal framework of [Bernanke, Gertler, and Gilchrist \(1999a\)](#) establishes the importance of nominal rigidities and financial frictions for monetary-policy transmission but models them as separate mechanisms. My work develops a microfoundation connecting them through a channel largely overlooked in prior models.

The central idea of these papers is that product-price adjustments convey information about firms' production costs, demand, total factor productivity, and other fundamentals to the public, including investors and lenders. When firms adjust prices less frequently, these signals reveal less about current conditions, increasing information frictions in capital markets. Combining accounting and economic theory with capital-market evidence, these papers examine how public information, reporting incentives, managers' strategic choices, and securities regulation shape this channel.

1.1. Capital-Market Consequences of Asymmetric Output-Price Rigidities

In [Xie \(2020\)](#), my PhD dissertation completed at HKUST, I employ a novel empirical approach derived from a menu-cost model à la [Ball and Mankiw \(1994\)](#) to empirically verify that firms' inability to adjust product prices downward in response to deflationary input-cost shocks imposes significant costs on shareholders. Drawing on survey evidence that a less persistent earnings path is less favored by managers and shareholders ([Graham, Harvey, and Rajgopal, 2005](#)), I show how these shareholder-borne costs, stemming from downward-price rigidities, manifest in the stock market through reduced earnings persistence, heightened stock-return volatility, and more frequent CEO interventions in managing Wall Street expectations. My study highlights the key distinction between New Keynesian models and their alternatives: while nominal rigidity is costly for firms in New Keynesian models, it is not in other models. The paper complements the contemporary work of [Gorodnichenko and Weber \(2016\)](#).

1.2. Price Rigidities and the Value of Public Information

In [Gu and Xie \(2024\)](#), coauthor and I document a novel channel through which firms' nominal rigidities exacerbate information asymmetries between corporate insiders and outsiders, while public information about firms' input-cost structure helps mitigate this informational friction. The potential mechanism is that inflexibility in adjusting output prices suppresses the revelation

²I use output-price stickiness and nominal rigidities interchangeably to mean infrequent adjustments in a firm's product prices.

of how input-cost shocks affect firms’ profits. To test our empirical hypothesis, we develop a novel measure of firms’ input cost visibility and take advantage of a unique quasi-experiment to exploit exogenous variation in that visibility. We verify that in a rich data setting, public information (about input costs) is especially valuable for firms with sticky-output prices. Our work provides an alternative mechanism to the cash-flow volatility channel through which firms with sticky-output prices are subject to more financial-market frictions than other firms (D’Acunto, Liu, Pflueger, and Weber, 2018).

1.3. Nominal Rigidities, Earnings Manipulation, and Securities Regulation

In Li, Wang, Xie, and Zhang (2025), coauthors and I develop and test a model linking nominal rigidities, earnings manipulation, and the macroeconomic effects of securities regulation. In the model, price changes reveal managers’ private information about profits, and mimicking firms must match the prices of the firms they imitate. The model predicts that managers of sticky-price firms are more likely to manipulate earnings, prompting lenders to demand higher loan spreads. Using a difference-in-differences design, we find that the passage and implementation of the Sarbanes–Oxley Act (SOX) curb this manipulation and lower borrowing costs for sticky-price firms. This mechanism departs from textbook models, which assume that managers maximize shareholder value subject to constraints on price adjustment. Our findings complement recent studies (e.g., Gorodnichenko and Weber, 2016; D’Acunto, Liu, Pflueger, and Weber, 2018) by identifying costs of nominal rigidities beyond cash-flow volatility that are not confined to monetary-policy shocks. Our study also contributes to the accounting literature on the general equilibrium effects of accounting regulation (Ball, 2024).

1.4. Price Rigidity and Financial Frictions

In Chai, Wang, and Xie (2026), my coauthors and I develop and test a broader framework in which product-price rigidity creates financial frictions through lenders’ costly verification of profits, beyond the cash-flow volatility channel studied by D’Acunto, Liu, Pflueger, and Weber (2018). Because prices signal demand, infrequent adjustment limits lenders’ information about realized demand and profits, increasing their need for costly verification. The model predicts that better verification increases leverage and reduces cash holdings at sticky-price firms, with little effect on flexible-price firms. We test these predictions using initial PCAOB inspections as shocks to third-party verification that may reduce lenders’ verification costs. Following inspections, firms with stickier prices exhibit larger increases in long-term leverage and larger declines in cash holdings, particularly when auditors were less independent of their clients before inspections. Firm volatility also declines among sticky-price firms, consistent with reduced investor-perceived uncertainty about fundamentals. We embed this mechanism in the framework of Bernanke, Gertler, and Gilchrist (1999b) to derive its macroeconomic implications.

1.5. Flexible Prices and CEO Relative Performance Evaluation

In Luo and Xie (2026), coauthor and I examine how product-price flexibility affects executive governance by amplifying CEO moral hazard and shaping boards’ retention decisions. Standard agency theory predicts that relative performance evaluation (RPE) is valuable when peer performance captures common shocks, allowing boards to insulate CEOs from luck. When managers can respond strategically to shocks, however, peer performance also reflects managerial choices,

and RPE can distort incentives. We find that boards of flexible-price firms rely less on RPE in CEO dismissal decisions than boards of sticky-price firms, a pattern not explained solely by CEO selection or a lack of suitable peers. Our model shows that RPE can induce managers to mimic peers to avoid relative underperformance or adopt contrarian pricing strategies to gamble for retention. Pricing flexibility expands the scope for these distortions, prompting boards to emphasize absolute performance to preserve optimal pricing incentives. Our findings suggest that the “performance-luck” puzzle — boards’ failure to fully filter common shocks from CEO dismissal decisions (Jenter and Kanaan, 2015) — can reflect a rational response to the agency costs of RPE.

2. Accounting and Firm Expectation

My first research strand examines how outsiders infer unobservable firm fundamentals from accounting information and product prices, placing more weight on price signals when accounting information is less reliable and less weight when it is more reliable. I extend this idea beyond price rigidity to examine how accounting information shapes firms’ inflation expectations, trade relationships, contracting decisions, and responses to securities regulation. For example, when an accounting scandal reveals a firm’s previously hidden problems, how do other firms revise their expectations and behavior? This question matters because firms’ expectations guide current investment and financing decisions and, collectively, influence the business cycle (e.g., Gennaioli et al., 2016; Weber et al., 2022).

2.1. *Undisclosed Material Inflation Risk*

In Konchitchki and Xie (2023), coauthor and I identify many major US corporations that are highly exposed to inflation risk. Yet, although the SEC legally requires the disclosure of possible risk factors, a majority of the inflation-exposed firms do not disclose inflation risk. However, after being sued in a securities class action lawsuit, while all firms increase the length of their reported risk factor texts, only the inflation-exposed firms are more likely to begin disclosing inflation risk.

The contribution of this study is as follows. Understanding managers’ attitudes toward inflation is of paramount importance because it influences key business decisions, such as when to adjust prices, wages, or finance projects. Both macroeconomic and microeconomic models highlight the role of firms’ inflation expectations in the Phillips curve, which links inflation to the real economy based on firm managers’ awareness of inflation (e.g., Lucas, 1972). Our findings suggest that managers may not be fully aware of inflation risks, which complements recent survey-based studies that often focus on small firms’ inattention to inflation dynamics (e.g., Coibion, Gorodnichenko, and Kumar, 2018; Candia, Coibion, and Gorodnichenko, 2024). In addition, by examining how managers disclose macroeconomic risks, our study contributes to existing research on limited attention and information disclosure in capital markets (e.g., Hirshleifer and Teoh, 2003).

2.2. *Accounting Standards and Antidumping Investigations*

In Sun, Wei, and Xie (2025), coauthors and I examine the consequences of harmonizing accounting standards on international trade through the lens of exporting firms’ experiences with foreign antidumping cases. We find the adoption of International Financial Reporting Standards by an exporting country increases the likelihood that its firms can successfully defend against allegations

of dumping in foreign markets. Our study speaks to the collateral (or incidental) benefits of financial globalization, which serves as an important catalyst for various indirect gains, including the development of domestic institutions (e.g., [Rajan and Zingales, 2003](#); [Kose, Prasad, Rogoff, and Wei, 2009](#)). This study extends the implications of a country’s adoption of IFRS beyond its capital markets and deepens our understanding of how the globalization of accounting standards enhances resource allocation and promotes economic efficiency. In particular, we show that the enforcement of financial reporting plays a key role in this context (e.g., [Christensen, Hail, and Leuz, 2013](#)).

2.3. The Sobering Effect of Peer Punishment on the Unpunished

In [D’Acunto, Weber, and Xie \(2026\)](#), coauthors and I examine whether the visibility of a peer’s punishment deters misconduct among non-punished peers. Because peers are more closely connected to the punished, they update their beliefs about the likelihood and consequences of punishment more strongly than non-peers. We test this mechanism in China by comparing how state-owned enterprises (SOEs) and non-SOEs react to the same peer’s punishment for fraudulent loan guarantees. Following such events, SOEs — whose CEOs face greater career concerns — significantly reduce their loan guarantees to related parties. This study shows that the “punish one, teach a hundred” effect of securities regulation can serve as an important alternative governance mechanism to mitigate tunneling through inter-corporate transactions by controlling shareholders (e.g., [Jiang, Lee, and Yue, 2011](#)). Punishments as governance mechanisms are cost-effective because they do not require the collection and elaboration of private information and can be applied in developing countries, where shareholder activism is not highly diffused due to the absence of large institutional investors in equity markets.

2.4. Trust and Contracts: Empirical Evidence

In [D’Acunto, Xie, and Yao \(2024\)](#), coauthors and I empirically examine the role of an important yet previously overlooked element in incomplete contract theory. Specifically, we test whether the extent of trust — defined as the subjective probability that principals and agents assign to future predatory actions by their counterparts in response to unplanned events — shapes the degree of completeness with which a principal-agent contract is written. In the context of consulting contracts between a principal (i.e., the firm’s shareholders/management) and an agent (i.e., the consultant), we introduce novel data sets and measures of contract completeness and use a quasi-exogenous shock to trust among contracting parties. We find contracts written in a lower trust environment are more complete, and new clauses added to contracts after trust drops are related to potential observable and verifiable misbehavior by agents or principals. Our empirical work informs a large body of theoretical literature on the drivers of contract incompleteness (e.g., [Tirole, 2009](#); [Gennaioli, La Porta, Lopez-de Silanes, and Shleifer, 2022](#)).

3. Market Distortion and Firm Innovation

The third strand of my research agenda draws on corporate finance and industrial organization to examine how distortions in product markets and restrictions on skilled labor mobility affect firms’ innovation decisions.

3.1. *Fake Entry*

In [Xie \(2021\)](#), [Xie and Gerakos \(2020\)](#) and [Schmalz and Xie \(2024\)](#), coauthors and I address a fundamental question in corporate finance: What is the objective function of a widely held firm? The Fisher separation theorem proves the following assumption that widely held corporations maximize their own value, irrespective of shareholder’s preferences ([Fisher, 1930](#)). The alternative theory, however, is that firms maximize the value of their most influential investors’ portfolios (e.g., [Azar, Schmalz, and Isabel, 2018](#); [Antón, Ederer, Giné, and Schmalz, 2023](#); [Ederer and Pellegrino, 2024](#)). Specifically, we document in a specific industry that some firms predictably make decisions that systematically destroy firms’ own value, while the same decision benefits the value of the portfolio of their largest shareholders. Specifically, we show the financial interests of a generic-drug manufacturer’s largest shareholders in a branded competitor predict the generic’s likelihood of being the first to challenge a drug patent. Conditional on a challenge, these common-ownership links predict settlements and delayed generic entry in exchange for payments to the generic. The stock price reactions are positive for the brand but negative for the generic, implying wealth transfers from one portfolio firm to another, with net benefits to investors. The conceptual importance of our findings is that they collectively reject the prediction of the Fisher separation theorem.

3.2. *Nationalist Labor Policies and Corporate Innovation*

In [D’Acunto, Huang, Weber, Xie, and Yang \(2025\)](#), coauthors and I ask whether restrictions on hiring highly skilled foreign workers reduce innovation at domestic firms. We study the 2009 U.S. Employ American Workers Act, which restricted new foreign hires at financial institutions receiving Troubled Asset Relief Program (TARP) funds while that funding remained outstanding. Comparing similarly troubled TARP institutions with different pre-crisis exposure to the unexpected restrictions, we find that more exposed banks hired fewer foreign workers and filed fewer, lower-quality patents, including in financial technology, cybersecurity, and payment systems. They did not compensate by acquiring external patents or increase domestic hiring. Instead, they paid higher wage premia to retain foreign employees hired before the crisis, relative to U.S. workers in the same occupations and locations. The study contributes to research on bank innovation ([Lerner, Seru, Short, and Sun, 2024](#)) and shows that restrictions on highly skilled immigration can reduce innovation without increasing domestic hiring. Such policies may also weaken national competitiveness by encouraging firms to move investment and innovation abroad ([Glennon, 2024](#)).³

³In September 2025, President Trump signed an order requiring a \$100,000 fee for new H-1B visa applications. See “[Trump to impose \\$100,000 fee per year for H-1B visas, in blow to tech](#),” Reuters, September 21, 2025.

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